

COMPLETED CASE HANDOUT

Digikala Instant Exchange

A completed Working Backwards example for presentation and discussion

What this handout is

- A complete model answer showing how the Working Backwards artifacts connect.
- A reference for discussion after the case walkthrough.
- Not a worksheet, real announcement, service description, launch plan, or policy.

CASE STATUS

The feature is fictional. All customer voice, targets, volumes, zones, operating details, and economics are illustrative assumptions.

STEP 1

Customer, struggle, and outcome

Element	Completed model answer
Target customer	Customer with a defective or incorrect eligible item who still needs the product soon.
Customer struggle	The return-refund-reorder path adds delay, steps, uncertainty, and time without the intended product.
Observable outcome	At least 80% of confirmed pilot exchanges complete within 48 hours. Target is illustrative.

Future promise

PROMISE

An eligible customer can replace a defective or incorrect same-SKU item in one scheduled courier visit, with the standard return path preserved if the swap fails.

Pilot boundary

In	Out
Digikala-fulfilled; in stock; same SKU	Different product, color, or size
Non-heavy products; selected reasons	Seller-fulfilled or heavy items
Three selected Tehran zones	General returns redesign or national launch
One courier swap; penalty-free fallback	Instant refund or open substitution

STEP 2

Future press release and experience

Headline

Digikala pilots one-visit exchanges for eligible purchases

Eligible customers can request a same-SKU replacement in the app; Digikala reserves it and a courier swaps it for the original item in one scheduled visit.

In this fictional future announcement, selected customers in three Tehran delivery zones can request an exchange without first completing a return and placing a new order. Confirmation appears only after the replacement is reserved.

The app shows request, reservation, appointment, and completion state. If the handoff cannot be completed, the customer retains the standard return path without penalty.

The pilot tests whether a tightly bounded one-visit experience can reduce effort while maintaining reservation integrity, quality, safety, accessibility, and economic control.

Customer experience

- Open the order and choose Request exchange for an eligible reason.
- Review eligibility, same-SKU replacement, handoff conditions, and fallback.
- Confirm only after the replacement is reserved.
- Choose an exchange window and receive status updates.
- Hand the original item to the courier and receive the replacement.
- See completion; if the visit fails, use the standard return path without penalty.

STEP 3

Hard FAQs and completed answers

Question	Completed answer
Is fallback penalty-free?	Yes. Ineligibility or a failed swap preserves the standard return path without penalty in the model case.
Can every user recover?	The flow requires clear language, screen-reader support, non-color cues, sufficient contrast, and an assisted path.
Can stock stay reserved?	Confirmation happens only after reservation. Loss, expiry, duplicates, cancellation, and reconciliation are pilot guardrails.
Can systems reconcile?	Order/returns, inventory, courier tasking, app state, support, risk, and analytics need observable transitions and recovery.
Is custody safe?	The courier handles two controlled assets with identifiers, checks, failure codes, safe-carry rules, and custody transitions.
What stops the pilot?	Safety, privacy or policy breach, uncontrolled reservation inconsistency, failed-swap breach, or unreconciled custody.
Are controls fair?	Begin with narrow transparent rules, review false positives, preserve fallback, and avoid opaque penalties.
Is the cost justified?	Validate courier handling, reverse logistics, reservation holding, loss/damage, support, engineering, and avoided recovery cost.

STEP 4

Evidence and assumption ledger

EVIDENCE RULE

An assumption becomes evidence only when its source, method, date, population, and limitations are recorded. A target is not a baseline.

Area	Illustrative assumption	Impact	How to learn	Owner
Customer need	Eligible customers value speed and certainty enough to choose one-visit exchange.	High	Interview + concept test	Designer
Eligibility	The narrow boundary produces enough volume to learn.	High	Historical eligibility analysis	Data
Reservation	Inventory can be reserved with fewer than 3% broken confirmations.	High	Shadow reservation	Tech Lead
Logistics	Courier routes can handle two-asset custody safely and reliably.	High	Operations simulation	EM
Handoff	Customers can prepare the original item and complete the swap in one visit.	Medium	Usability + dry run	Design / QA
Support	No more than 10% of requests require support contact.	Medium	Instrumented pilot	PM / Data
Misuse	Narrow rules control misuse without unfair customer exclusion.	High	Risk + false-positive review	Sponsor / Data
Economics	Incremental cost is justified by customer value and avoided recovery cost.	High	Pilot unit economics	Sponsor

Worked ledger row

Replacement stock stays reserved until the swap completes — Assumption, high impact — Learn with a shadow reservation test — Tech Lead before any live pilot.

MEASUREMENT AND RISK

Illustrative guardrails

Metric	Illustrative target
Primary outcome	≥80% of confirmed exchanges complete within 48 hours.
Customer effort	≥20% lower effort score than measured baseline.
Reservation integrity	<3% of confirmed requests lose the reserved replacement.
Failed swap	<5% of visits fail for an avoidable process reason.
Support contact	≤10% of requests generate an exchange-related contact.
Safety	Zero serious incidents attributable to the pilot.

Highest-impact risks

Risk	Consequence	Mitigation / evidence	DRI
Broken reservation	Customer loses trust after confirmation.	Shadow test; expiry and reconciliation.	Tech Lead
Failed handoff	Extra effort and two disrupted assets.	Prep guidance, failure codes, safe fallback.	EM / QA
State inconsistency	App, courier, and support conflict.	Source of truth and observability.	Tech Lead
Accessibility gap	Customer cannot complete or recover.	Research, criteria, assisted path.	Designer
Courier safety	Harm, loss, or unclear custody.	Simulation and custody scan.	EM
Poor learning validity	Pilot drives the wrong decision.	Population funnel and denominator audit.	Data

IMPORTANT

Data must confirm definitions, baselines, denominators, segments, and validity before these illustrative targets guide a real decision.

EXPERIMENT

Staged plan and decision rule

Stage	Illustrative design	Exit evidence	DRI
1. Customer evidence	5–8 interviews plus concept test.	Problem strength, comprehension, value, recovery.	Designer
2. State prototype	Clickable customer and support flows.	Usability and accessibility evidence.	Design / QA
3. Shadow reservation	Controlled SKU set; no live promise.	Integrity, expiry, and reconciliation.	Tech Lead
4. Operations simulation	Internal courier and custody dry runs.	Safety, capacity, failure taxonomy.	EM / QA
5. Limited live pilot	≤500 invitations; three zones; four weeks or 300 completed.	Outcome and guardrails.	PM
6. Decision review	Written evidence pack and sponsor decision.	Expand, iterate, pause, or stop.	Sponsor

Decision rule

- Expand if the primary outcome and effort direction are met, guardrails hold, and no hard stop occurs.
- Iterate if customer value is evident but reversible process guardrails miss.
- Pause if measurement validity, reservation integrity, or operational control is insufficient.
- Stop if the problem is weak, fallback cannot be protected, economics are disproportionate, or a serious safety/privacy/policy condition occurs.

GOVERNANCE

Decision rights and worked conflict

Decision	DRI	Required input
Customer outcome + PR/FAQ	Product Manager	Design, Data, QA
Research + interaction	Designer	PM, QA, Engineers
Technical direction	Tech Lead	Engineers, EM, QA
Capacity + delivery health	Engineering Manager	TL, Engineers, PM
Implementation evidence	Named engineer	TL, QA, Data
Release confidence	QA	Design, TL, Engineers
Metrics + learning validity	Data Analyst	PM, QA, Engineers
Irreversible investment / policy	Named sponsor	Other sponsor + relevant DRI

Worked conflict record

Field	Completed record
Decision	Live pilot now, or shadow reservation first?
Evidence	Reservation loss and state reconciliation are unknown.
Owner	Tech Lead recommends; named sponsor ratifies exposure.
Reversibility	Shadow test is reversible; a live customer promise is not.
Decision	Run shadow reservation before any live pilot.
Commitment	Record dissent, action, owner, guardrail, and review checkpoint.

SUMMARY

Four habits to carry into real decisions

Habit	Practice
Customer first	Name a specific struggle and observable outcome.
Future promise	Write the experience and boundary before the mechanism.
Evidence	Label assumptions and run the cheapest credible tests.
Ownership	Name one DRI; write the decision; use a sponsor for hard-to-reverse commitments.

Sources

- Approved Working Backwards project brief supplied by the requester, 5 August 2026.
- Colin Bryar and Bill Carr, Working Backwards, St. Martin's Press, 2021, for general method background.
- Digikala Instant Exchange Completed PR/FAQ, illustrative internal case model, 5 August 2026.

DISCUSSION PROMPT

Challenge the promise, evidence, boundary, or decision right. If one changes, identify which experiment or decision must change with it.